

Introduction - City Lights

The wind brushes against my cheeks, gently swaying my hair.

I am on the eighth floor of an old apartment building with a sterile exterior. Looking out at the city through the open window calms my mind, and I lose track of time. The twilight transforms the cluttered landscape into something resembling a beautiful painting. The air, swollen with the orange glow of the setting sun, blankets the city and envelops me.

Today, too, I am here, breathing, living.

The sun that had been illuminating the surroundings dropped away suddenly, and as the skyline of the buildings stretching to the west turned purple, warm lights began to flicker on across the city one after another.

I love watching the lights of this city. In those countless glimmers, I feel the warmth of people living through the same moment in time.

Yet, at the same time, I feel as though I am standing outside that scenery. While I wish to be within those lights, I possess neither the courage to mingle with others nor the strength to believe fully in myself.

Happiness—the kind that surely exists where those lights shine. I simply think of those happy lives in silence.

The summer I was fifteen, a second-year high school student. Though it is an age where adults push you forward, telling you that "you can become anything," I have always been anxious. Even though I intend to live my life with all my might, a sense of discomfort—as if I am hiding alone in a dim shadow—never disappears. I cannot explain to myself why I am so anxious or why I carry such a drifting, homeless heart.

Arguments with my parents, the fact that I'm not growing as tall as I'd like, the fact that my hands are too small to play the guitar well, the heartless comments I received on a video I posted to NicoNico Dōga yesterday... I ruminate on each of these things and sink into depression. Like a frozen computer, my mind occasionally stops moving, leaving me staring at a pitch-black screen.

A lukewarm wind blows strongly inside, and my long hair falls across my face. Closing the window, I shake my head to fix my hair, and a blue Stratocaster leaning against the wall catches the corner of my eye.

My parents bought me that guitar for my thirteenth birthday, but I left it neglected for several years and never learned to play a single song. A few months ago, I picked it up again, deciding that I wanted to be able to play a song I wrote and composed myself by the time I graduated high school; however, the skin on my left fingertips only peels away, and I am far from producing a vivid sound.

"I really have no talent," I whispered with a sigh.

I was afraid that if I committed myself seriously, I would ultimately discover that I simply couldn't do it. Realizing this weakness in myself, I spoke firmly to my own heart.

Don't be afraid.

Summer has arrived in earnest. In the room with the closed window, a damp heat accumulates. I pick up the guitar and sit cross-legged, leaning against the wall. I begin to translate the chest-splitting pain into words. The world I set to melody is filled with emotions I usually keep capped and hidden; it is prickly and abrasive throughout.

But I do not flinch. I will not let go of this intensity—an intensity so fierce that if you grasp it, your hand will be cut and bleed.

The only time I can do this is now, at sixteen, in this very moment.

I strike the strings with my pick, groping for the chords. The raw sound of the guitar, without an amplifier, makes a dry, scratching noise.

Am I trying to find redemption by hurting others, and hurting myself?

"Maybe I can be happy...!" (Laughs)

Drunk again on the early summer breeze

I sing of my conceited ego

I don't know the right answer, so

Tell me

Tell me!

The words I loved have been broken

Even though I believed that someday I would be rewarded

This voice I've built up is the "incorrect answer" of this world

"I hate that face of yours, knowing nothing."

Dozens, hundreds, thousands of times

I want to die

The exhilaration and the shame of singing the raw screams of my heart swirled in my head, and I instinctively stopped playing the guitar. Does anyone really want to hear my true feelings poured into such painful lyrics?

Sometimes, I think that the world I am aiming for is like a glass chandelier. When I look up, it sways gently, and I am captivated by its brilliance. But if it were to fall to the ground, it would shatter in an instant and lose its light. Only wreckage that makes one want to cover their eyes would remain.

That's why it's better not to have dreams. Like cold water splashed over heated emotions, someone's voice echoes in my mind.

Do you seriously think you have talent?

Do you think your voice and singing style will be accepted by everyone?

Do you really believe you can continue to live as an "Utaite"?

And yet—my heart catches the light and glows faintly, and I can certainly feel a possibility for the future reflected there.

The day I discovered Vocaloid at age six, and the day I posted my first "Utatemita" video at age fourteen, became the turning point that changed my life.

Even though the place I live and the scenery I see remain unchanged, the world connected by voice expanded with a loud resonance. It was fun, and I sang every day. Inspired by many other Utaite, I re-recorded countless times and sent my singing and my voice across the screen to the other side.

I have never felt that I "won" against anyone until now. Whether in appearance or studies, I cannot compare myself to others. But singing alone was my pride. No matter what headwinds blew, I wanted to be an Utaite.

To calm my racing pulse, I hug the guitar tightly.

I don't even know about the future.

I don't know what the future holds. Even if I am lonely now, even if I hate myself, even if someone denies me—no one knows what my future will be but me.

As I muttered this, the indefinable anxiety eased slightly. And I carved it into my heart once more: even if a deeper darkness visits me in the future, I will never let go of my singing.

Chapter One - An Adult I Could Trust

Hey. At what age did you stop believing in adults?

I found myself asking this silently to the backs of strangers. Over and over again.

As I hurried across the Shibuya scramble crossing, as I gripped the strap of a train on the Yamanote Line, or as I stood in a long queue at a drugstore checkout—peering through the gaps in my long bangs with a look of sheer exhaustion, I asked them without a word.

I hate adults.

I loathed people who would throw cruel words at someone just because they were a student, all while wearing a faint, mocking smile.

"Seriously, what is up with that falsetto?"

"The voice is too loud; it's not for me."

"No matter how you look at it, that's not a style that will sell."

Just remembering those words makes me dizzy; flashes of light streak across the back of my eyes. Trying to shake off the voices that refuse to leave my ears, I turn on my microphone inside a dim closet. I take a breath and sing, but halfway through, I suddenly feel sorry for myself.

*Actors School: A training school for learning the fundamentals of entertainment fields such as singing, dancing, and acting.

Before the tears could fall, I wiped them away with my right sleeve and sang again.

I wonder if the wounds in my heart will heal once I become an adult.

I wonder if I'll ever be able to brush off the act of people laughing at another's hard work with a straight face.

Another wave of self-loathing washes over me. The moment I think that not only do I hate myself, but others hate me too, I feel as though there is no salvation left for me, and my fingertips turn ice-cold.

September 2019. Autumn of my second year at a correspondence high school.

At the Actors School* I attended alongside high school, everyone was talking about auditions for talent agencies every single day.

"I'm going to try out for the audition hosted by ○○ Records."

"Maybe I'll challenge myself with an acting audition, not just singing."

"I think I'll perform at a festival with my band and wait to be scouted."

My peers in the vocal course—all of different ages and backgrounds—spoke with voices full of ambition.

Beside them, I gave a small shake of my head. I had a vague desire to debut as a professional while still in high school, but the days of lessons passed by without me ever taking concrete action.

*In my Twitter DMs, I occasionally received scouting messages from talent agencies or record companies. But I couldn't believe that anyone would be interested in me; fearing it might be a scam, I turned them all down.

When I think about my future, my thoughts grow muddy and my vision blurs. *I have to think more seriously, more realistically, about all this...* While letting out a deep sigh, I came up with an audacious idea in an attempt to rouse my frail self.

One day, Ado will hold a solo concert.

Even though I didn't say it aloud, the words echoed loudly in my head. Immediately, another version of myself appeared to call me out on this sudden declaration.

Wait, wait. When is "one day"?

How far into the future are we talking?

I am bad at planned preparation. Even with my summer homework in elementary school, I would put it off until the very last day and finish it through a sleepless night of crying. Years have passed since then, but fundamentally, nothing has changed. If I'm not backed into a corner, I probably won't do anything. If I can't make my dream come true here, I might end up as some twisted, overly intellectual adult.

Don't I need to move?

And if so, isn't now the time?

Huddled in the dim closet with my knees pulled to my chest, I repeated those words in my mind over and over.

Today, September 1, 2019, is—so to speak—the "last day of summer vacation." If I don't move now, I'll surely procrastinate again, telling myself, "I'll do it tomorrow." I want to end the days of running away, once and for all.

At night, shortly after 10:00 PM. In my room, I tore a single sheet of paper from a notebook on my desk. Using a thick marker, I wrote in large letters:

I will perform a concert at Zepp DiverCity on 1/10!

I taped it to my bedroom door with cellophane tape and whispered a small "Alright." Returning to my desk, I operated my smartphone to start a live stream, and the number of viewers began to climb slowly. Wow, 200 people have already gathered.

I steadied my breathing. Lifting my phone, I showed the declaration taped to the door on the screen and said:

"Good evening, everyone. Um... I, Ado, will be holding a solo concert at Zepp DiverCity on January 10, 2021."

The moment those words left my mouth, a sudden burst of sweat broke out. *Whoa, I actually said it.* The date that had popped into my head was January 10th, the anniversary of my first "Utatemita" video upload. Now that I've said it, there is no escape. But I'm terrified. After ending the stream, unable to sit still, I posted my panic on Twitter.

<I just declared that I'll do a solo concert at Zepp DiverCity on 2021/1.10... what do I do... >

Unable to stay still, I paced around the house. To cool my flushed cheeks, I splashed my face with water from the bathroom sink and shook my head like a dog to clear the droplets. Why was I, someone so timid, able to say something so bold? Staring at myself in the mirror, I let out a soft breath.

Suddenly, those DMs crossed my mind. Why now, when nothing has even started yet? I can't put the reason into words perfectly, but from the moment I saw that message, I felt as though a small gear had begun to turn somewhere.

I received that person's message on a midsummer afternoon, wrapped in a heat that felt inescapable no matter where I went. On my way home from school, I opened Twitter while walking and found a DM from a mysterious account.

<Nice to meet you.
My name is Chigira, and I run a music agency.
I have seen your Twitter and YouTube.
Are you currently affiliated with any agency?
Would it be possible for us to meet once?

Cloud Nine, Takuya Chigira>

Cloud Nine...? I've never heard of an agency by that name.

Just because a talent agency reached out didn't mean I took it seriously. I intended to decline as usual, but for the time being, I typed "Cloud Nine" into the search bar and tapped enter. A homepage appeared, and among the list was the name of one artist I recognized. My heart gave a heavy thud.

I had once been saved by an anime that featured that artist singing the ending theme. Back in my third year of middle school, when I was barely attending school and staying shut in my house, touching only the things I loved, it was my favorite anime. The driving sound of that ending song and lyrics that captured the freshness of youth made me feel exhilarated. Even while withdrawn from society, I felt strangely not lonely.

Huh, if it's the agency that artist belongs to, I might be a little interested, I thought, but meeting someone suddenly was scary. Furthermore, school rules forbade contacting talent agencies without permission. After some hesitation, I sent back a polite message of refusal.

<Nice to meet you, and thank you for the DM.
I am not currently affiliated with an agency, but I am studying singing at an Actors School while attending a correspondence high school. Since the school has prohibited us from discussing work or scouting offers from agencies, I am afraid I cannot meet your request, despite it being a generous offer. If our paths cross again in the future, I would love to hear more. Thank you for contacting me. Ado>

I was curious about that ending song, but it couldn't be helped.

And so, the exchange ended—or so I thought. However, a few days after my solo concert declaration, believe it or not, another message arrived from Mr. Chigira, whom I had already turned down.

"I understand your position, Ado.

If you're open to it, why don't we meet and talk once—strictly off the clock?

I might be able to offer some advice that could be of help to you.

Chigira"

Chigira, Chigira, Takuya Chigira... I searched for him, and I found a hit.

What! Mr. Chigira was the manager for GRReeeN*? He's someone from the professional world. It's scary to meet a stranger, but his wording is polite; maybe it's okay just to meet and talk. But what if he suddenly changes his personality the moment we meet and starts saying terrifying things...?

While I wavered in indecision, the solo concert I had recently announced flashed through my mind. Every time I opened the message, my chest tightened. Feeling that I couldn't move forward like this, I made a bold decision to meet him.

The date we settled on via DM was September 27, 2019. We agreed to meet in Ebisu at 6:00 PM.

Without telling the Actors School—let alone my parents—I headed to Ebisu alone. Consequently, I was terrified inside. What if he's a weirdo? What if I get kidnapped and sold into slavery...? Well, worst case scenario, I'll just scream my head off for help and run away with everything I've got!

After finishing my lessons at the school, on my way to Ebisu Station, I sent a confirmation DM to Mr. Chigira, and we immediately began exchanging messages.

*GRReeeN: Now known as GRRe4N BOYZ

Ado: Thank you for your hard work. Just confirming that we are still scheduled to meet in Ebisu today at 6:00 PM...?

Chigira: Looking forward to it! I'm just about to get on the Yamanote Line from Shinjuku!

Ado: Is there a specific area in Ebisu that works best for you?

Chigira: No preference! Would it be better if I waited for you at the station...?

Chigira: Would a coffee shop be okay?

Ado: That's fine with me!

Chigira: There is a coffee shop called Renoir at the East Exit of Ebisu; would that work?

Ado: That works. I'll wait for you there...

While swaying in the train, I imagined what Mr. Chigira—the agency president and former manager of GReeeeN—looked like. He probably wears an Armani suit, black-rimmed glasses, and has his hair slicked back with wax. The quintessential look of a capable adult professional. But what if he's scary?

Chigira: I'm almost there too!

Ado: Understood. I'll be waiting...

Chigira: I've arrived. Ah, my apologies! The coffee shop is full, so for now, I'll wait in front of the store!

Ado: Oh no! I'm sorry for making you wait...

Chigira: I'm almost there too... Wait, it's only 5:50. It's totally fine!

Ado: I've arrived...

As soon as I spotted the entrance to Renoir, I sent the message and looked around. An Armani suit and black-rimmed glasses... I don't see anyone like that anywhere...

"Are you Ado?"

Startled by a voice from behind, I turned around to find a man standing there who looked like an out-of-season surfer.

With long hair and a beard, he was wearing a T-shirt and shorts, holding nothing but a smartphone in his hand.

Wait, who is this? Did the wrong person come?

For a moment, my throat tightened and I froze, unable to speak, but I first gave a polite bow to avoid being rude.

"Hello... I'm Ado..."

As I bowed, what came into view were his bare feet and flip-flops.

Flip-flops in Ebisu at the end of September? Is he on his way back from Shonan? Whoa, and he's wearing a misanga around his ankle! Does he have some kind of wish...?

While distracted by his shocking footwear, I tensed my legs so I could run if necessary and stared intently at the man before me.

"Hello, I'm Chigira."

Because Mr. Chigira looked nothing like what I had imagined, every possible thought raced through my mind; my eyes must have been wide open like a baby chick's.

Since Renoir was full and we couldn't get a seat, Mr. Chigira suggested, "Let's move somewhere else."

"It's already dinner time. Do you want to eat something?"

"No, I'm okay."

"Then for now, let's go somewhere quiet where we can talk."

Mr. Chigira named a burger shop a few minutes' walk away and began walking ahead of me.

Is now the time to run? What if his accomplices are waiting at that burger shop?

My fear fueled further imaginings, but my desire to hear what Mr. Chigira had to say didn't fade. In the end, watching those flip-flops go *pata-pata*, I quietly followed behind him.

"...Nice to meet you, I'm Ado."

"I'm Chigira. Thank you for coming today."

"O-oh, no, thank you for contacting me."

The burger shop was empty, and we took a seat by the window.

"Ado, you're more slender than I expected."

"...Huh."

Mr. Chigira, who said he had watched all of my "Utatemita" videos, continued to share his impressions.

"Man, you're a great singer. Exceptionally great. And your voice is the best. Your voice is an incredible voice that someone would never forget once they've heard it. That's truly important for an Utaite. Even so, I thought you were a larger person with a sturdy frame. I just assumed you

had a big build, which is why you have that volume and that resonant, thick voice that sticks in the ear. I didn't think you'd be this slender."

I was happy to have my singing and voice praised, and thinking that people who watch my videos might indeed imagine me as someone more physically imposing made me almost laugh. However, since Mr. Chigira was right in front of me, I hurriedly tightened my lips. Seeing my solemn expression, Mr. Chigira continued his questioning.

"Where do you live?"

"Um, Toshima Ward."

"You're a high school student, right?"

"Yes, I'm a second-year, 15 years old. I'll be 16 on October 24th next month. I attend a correspondence high school, and on weekdays I go to the Actors School. That's where I learn singing and choreography."

"What do your parents do?"

"Um... various things."

"And the singing... When did you start?"

"I've loved singing since I was a child; I used to sing at home. I started posting to Niconico Dōga when I was 14."

Once he finished his questions for me, Mr. Chigira began talking about himself.

"I'm 35 now, and this February I established a music agency called Cloud Nine. Before that, I was the manager for a male vocal group."

I decided to keep it a secret that I had Googled him.

However, not that I doubt the profile I saw online, but is this man in shorts and flip-flops really the manager of GReeeeN—the people who sang "Ai Uta" and "Kiseki"? Really? The possibility that he's a scammer isn't zero... I almost let out a groan at the suspicion welling up in my chest, but I pretended to be composed and nodded along with a "Is that so?" When Mr. Chigira started talking about GReeeeN, the corners of his mouth lifted, and his expression became very gentle.

"After graduating university, I was doing another job unrelated to music. When I was 25, I became the manager for that group—"

"...I got a call from an acquaintance, and that's how I started working at their agency. I quickly became the manager for that group, and for four years, I listened to their music from the closest possible vantage point. Through that, I was moved by the beauty of music; I fell in love with it. But it wasn't just that. Their songs taught me that 'gratitude toward others' and 'a spirit that never gives up' are what truly matter. It made me feel like, *I can do this too!* And so, I decided to take a challenge of my own in the music industry."

W-what a positive and honest person... Looking at Mr. Chigira with that refreshing smile, it felt like there was no way he could be plotting something sinister. No, no—it's still too early to trust him. The needle of my heart swayed left and right like a metronome.

Mr. Chigira resumed his questioning. The fear I had initially felt was gradually fading, and I found myself able to speak calmly.

"Why the name Ado?"

"Um, I just liked the sound of 'Ado,' so I spelled it with the alphabet as Ado. As for the origin... it's from Kyōgen."

"Kyōgen?"

"In Kyōgen, the lead role is called the *shite*, and the supporting role is called the *ado*. I took it from there."

"Huh. So it means a supporting role. If you can become like a lead while having a name that means 'supporting role,' that's actually incredibly cool. So, Ado-san, what is it that you want to do?"

A supporting role becoming the lead? He certainly says some bold things... I hesitated for a moment, wondering how much of the truth I should reveal to someone I had just met, but slowly, I began to put my feelings into words.

024

"In middle school, I became a shut-in and couldn't have an enjoyable student life. That's why... I entered a correspondence high school, and because I wanted to study singing, I take lessons at an actor's school every day. But even now, I still can't find confidence in myself, and there's no one I feel I can truly trust. But... that's exactly why I want to create memories as vivid as fireworks while I'm still in my teens."

"What kind of memories?"

"Before I graduate from high school, I want to hold a live show at Zepp DiverCity. I've made up my mind that I'll absolutely do it. In fact... during a recent livestream, I declared that I would hold a solo concert on January 10th, 2021."

"Is that so? That's amazing. Zepp, huh? But why there?"

"I saw a live show by an artist I admire at Zepp DiverCity. The person standing on that stage was shining so brilliantly that I couldn't look at them directly. On the way home from that show, I decided that I wanted to stand on that stage too. Nothing has ever happened in my life until now; I felt that if I could perform at that dream stage, I could leave my mark while I'm still a teenager."

The moment I finished speaking, I was hit by an intense wave of regret. How foolish of me to tell a stranger in beach sandals about such an absurd dream. He's bound to laugh at me. Oh god, I shouldn't have said anything...

I want to sing as if I'm screaming from the center of the stage. I want to rivet the eyes of the audience on the other side of the microphone. But there's no way I can do that as I am now. Because I haven't changed at all since the days when I would cheer so loudly my cheeks burned, looking up at the Utaite bathed in light upon the stage.

025 Chapter 1: An Adult I Can Trust

And yet, in front of this person, I found myself blurting out things I didn't even need to say. He had a strange aura about him.

"I see. You want to stand on that stage, sing, and leave your mark before you're twenty. That's a great goal! But if it's by the time you graduate high school, you only have a year and a half left, right?"

Mr. Chigira continued the conversation without laughing at my words. While I felt a slight sense of relief, his mention of "a year and a half" made my spirits sink again, and I looked down. Even if I said something cool about "leaving a mark," I felt pathetic and frustrated that I still hadn't even entered a single audition.

Curious to see what expression Mr. Chigira wore after hearing such a preposterous dream, I timidly looked up. For some reason, he was grinning broadly, looking like he was having the time of his life.

What is with this bright smile???

"Well then, I'll get Zepp DiverCity for you."

"Eh? What do you mean?"

"I mean, I'll book Zepp for Ado-san."

"I-I-I'm happy to hear that... but why?"

"I mean, wouldn't it be great if your dream came true? So, is there anything else? What do you do after the Zepp live is over? Like, what's the goal beyond that?"

026

"I don't really know about the far future, but... yeah, I'd like to make Saitama Super Arena my ultimate goal..."

Ah, I said it. This is on the level of an elementary schooler saying they want to go to the moon.

Panicking, I added in a voice that was almost a whisper:

"I mean, that's a dream within a dream... this is actually the first time I've ever told anyone this..."

With enough momentum to drown out my timid correction, Mr. Chigira cut in with a "Well then."

"First, I'll get Zepp. That way, one of Ado-san's dreams comes true, right? Please, let me help you."

H-he'll get Zepp first...? The words were delivered so lightly that it felt as if something had snapped with a loud *thump* deep inside my heart. The image of the massive stage and myself shining upon it suddenly became three-dimensional and surged up before my eyes.

I steadied my breathing to interrupt this sudden daydream and brought my floating heart back down to earth.

"No, as I mentioned in the DMs, I can't just sign a contract with an agency on my own..."

"Of course you don't have to sign a contract. I just want to help with Ado-san's first live show."

"But..."

"But it is your dream, right?"

"Yes, it's my dream. And I don't want it to end as just a dream."

The fact that I had declared it on the livestream was pushing me forward with immense force.

"Um... can I ask you one thing?"

"Go ahead, anything."

"Am I... okay as I am now?"

"You're fine! If it's Ado-san's singing, you're more than fine. Though, there are risks. Like the capacity not filling up—or Ado-san running away."

"I'd run away...? If that happened, what would happen?"

"We'd just have to swallow the deficit."

The deficit... how much? Am I a high school student who's going to be saddled with debt!?!

"I have no idea how many people would actually come. But, roughly 8 million yen?"

"A deficit of... how many millions?"

"Eight million..." There's no way I could pay that. So, Mr. Chigira—who is practically a stranger—would pay it? I can't possibly cause that much trouble...

"...I wonder what happens if there's an 8-million-yen deficit. That would mean my life is over, right?"

I suddenly felt gloomy and sucked the last of my melted iced tea through the straw with a loud *slurp*.

Then, Mr. Chigira, with his arms crossed, gave a small laugh. What's so funny!?!?

"True. If that happens, let's just release a song called '8 Million Yen Deficit.'"

"Eh?"

"We'll deal with it when we deal with it, hahaha!"

"No, I mean... uh... hahaha."

Is he joking? Or does he just not understand the weight of 8 million yen!? Maybe this person really is dangerous...

I spoke with Mr. Chigira for a little over two hours. I told my dreams to someone I'd just met, was surprised multiple times, and in the end, we looked at each other and laughed. The idea that he

would book Zepp for an unknown high school student he had just met was shocking; by the time I left, even his departing beach sandals seemed to sparkle.

When I got home, I thought about it.

Mr. Chigira never once brought up the topic of a contract. He's someone who respects my pace.

Joining his agency might actually be interesting. I want to try it. But I haven't negotiated with my school yet; if I join secretly and get caught, it'll be a disaster.

I decided to call my *MIX engineer* for advice. Since they are older than me and more experienced, they might know how the industry works.

"A person named Mr. Chigira from Cloud Nine contacted me, and when we met to talk, he said he would book Zepp DiverCity for me and make my dream come true. What do you think...?"

The person on the other end lowered their voice.

"That is scary. I don't see why anyone would go that far for a high school student with no track record, especially upon their first meeting."

"Ah... I thought so..."

A chill ran down my spine. Come to think of it, I hadn't even told him my real name. When we parted ways at the burger shop, I had simply given him my phone number and we connected via LINE.

"But then again, it is strange. If there were no merit in it, I don't think they would have made such a proposal in the first place... Perhaps..."

"Perhaps...?"

"Maybe it wasn't to deceive you, but because they genuinely liked Ado's singing from the bottom of their heart."

"Eh, do you think so? Could that really happen? If it's true, I'd be happy."

After hanging up with the MIX engineer*, I remembered Takuya Chigira—the man who had called my singing "the best," even though it was never praised at school. What I was searching for was an adult I could trust. Someone who wouldn't dominate or bind me, someone who wouldn't lie, and someone who would face my music with sincerity.

I'll trust him. I'll try to believe in him. I'll try to tell him exactly how I feel.

Having decided this, I began to communicate with Chigira-san on a daily basis. I also consulted him via phone and LINE about offers I had received from other agencies.

"I was approached by ○○ Agency; they told me they just wanted me to listen to what they had to say."

"Yeah, why not? Since there's a possibility you'll join some agency eventually, it's better to hear out various options. The conditions will differ, and the atmosphere of each office will be different too."

However, when I actually met with them, they didn't invite me to be an Utaite; instead, they asked, "Why not become a VTuber?"

I could only manage a weak "I see..." in response. Unable to bring myself to flatly refuse, I trudged back home.

When I told Chigira-san about it over the phone, he simply said, "I see. I know the people at that agency, so I'll handle it from my end." He brushed away my worries in an instant.

"I feel bad asking this of you when I'm not even one of your signed artists," I said, feeling intimidated.

Chigira-san's calm voice reached my ears.

"You don't need to worry about that at all. Ado-san, just focus on the singing."

Ah, as I thought, Chigira-san is the only person who understands my dream and wants to help me achieve it. I want him to manage me!

The phrase "just focus on the singing" resonated deeply in my chest, and my resolve hardened.

But there was a problem: the school. At the Actors School, it was forbidden to take auditions or sign contracts with music agencies without the school's mediation.

I stood there, arms crossed, pondering for a while. After much hesitation, I let out a small sigh.

It's no use; I can't find the answer by thinking alone. It might put him in a difficult position, but next time, I'll tell him my honest feelings.

Shortly after entering December 2019, I met up with Chigira-san at a cafe in Shibuya. Staring down at his ever-present flip-flops, I spoke.

"Um... if it's truly possible, I want to be able to consult Chigira-san about things other than just the live show. Is that something you could do?"

My voice was surprisingly dark—hardly the expression of someone asking a favor. But inside, I was screaming: *Chigira-san, you are the only adult I can trust!*

I then re-explained why I wanted Chigira-san's help specifically, rather than a scout or an audition from a talent agency.

"As I mentioned before, it's forbidden to sign with an agency without going through the school. For now, since you're just helping me personally, I think we should keep it quiet from the school. But if I ever officially sign with Cloud Nine in the future, I intend to discuss it with the school staff then. I don't know when that will be, but..."

As I spoke, I became increasingly uncomfortable, feeling as though I wanted to vanish into thin air.

Chigira-san didn't seem bothered by my hesitation; instead, he spoke rapidly.

"If I'm going to help you continuously and not just for a single live show, then we have to notify the school now. I'll contact them myself."

Swept away by his momentum, I replied:

"Please do."

Chigira-san pressed his lips into a thin, firm line—so tight you could almost hear it click. Straightening my posture, I told him my real name for the first time.

"My real name is Ao Sawaki. I'm an only child, and I live with my parents."

On the way home, expectation and anxiety alternated in my chest, leaving me restless.

What will happen now? Will my dream of performing a live show as an Utaite actually come true? Or will Chigira-san be manipulated by the scary adults of the industry—twisted like a baby's wrist—and disappear?

Sigh... life isn't easy, I thought.

The sun set and night fell. When I opened my bedroom window, the cold winter wind slightly eased the suffocating feeling in my chest.

The following afternoon, I received this LINE message from Chigira-san:

《I called the school and told the office staff that I want to help Ado-san. I let them know that you aren't signed to an agency, and I asked if I could come by to introduce myself to the school directly.》

The faces of the office staff flashed through my mind, and my body felt heavy.

But the moment I read the next sentence, it was as if a sudden rain shower had passed and my vision suddenly cleared.

《And, per Ado-san's wish, I have secured Zepp DiverCity for January 10th, 2021. Now, all that's left is to charge forward toward making the dream a reality.》

I can do a solo live at Zepp DiverCity!

I can stand on that dream stage and sing!

The membrane of anxiety that had covered my entire body popped, and I felt as though I could finally take a deep breath.

《Thank you so much...! I'll do my best to become an Utaite worthy of that stage.》

《You can do it, Ado-san. It's okay.》

Hope circulated through my entire body along with my blood.

From that day on, Chigira-san and I spoke on the phone almost every day. It wasn't uncommon for us to talk for three or four hours at night. I poured out the feelings that had accumulated like layers of sediment—my desire to continue 활동 as "Ado," my wish to convey the brilliance of Vocaloids to the world, and my resolve to live not as a "singer" but as an "Utaite." I was amazed that there was an adult who would listen to these thoughts.

Even while taking the same routine vocal lessons at school, I felt in my heart as if I had gained the freedom of the entire world.

Chigira-san hadn't changed a bit since the day we met. Out of consideration for the school's situation, he never once mentioned management contracts or agency affiliation. The only thing that changed was that he stopped adding "-san" and began calling me Ao or Ado.

Even as January 2020 arrived, there was no response from the school to Chigira-san.

Why has the conversation stopped...

While time passed with the school ignoring him, I constantly encouraged myself: *Be an Utaite who can stand on the Zepp stage in one year!* Strangely, the videos I uploaded while pushing myself this way began to see an increase in views.

When I closed my eyes, I could see the shining stage. I saw myself illuminated in the center of a single beam of light, singing and dancing. If I could stand on that stage, sing, and savor that view into my memory, I wondered if I could like myself a little more than I do now...

Huddled in my closet, I softly embraced the modest happiness that filled my chest every night as I sang.

There was about one year left until the Zepp DiverCity live. Following Chigira-san's advice, I began making concrete preparations bit by bit.

What songs should I sing? What should the stage look like? What costumes should I wear? Everything I thought about led back to the solo live; before I knew it, my head was full of it every single day. When Chigira-san asked me about my image for the show, I described my ideal vision exactly as I imagined it.

"Right now, I've only shown myself through my illustration icon on social media, but I have this desire to truly project a strong presence during a live performance. It feels worlds apart from who I am now, but for some reason, that feeling keeps welling up inside me. Even while keeping my face hidden, I want to create a show where the audience can fully focus on both my singing and my performance. Though... it might be impossible..."

After hearing me out, Takuya Chigira began making various preparations from the very next day—everything from sound and lighting and hiring staff to strategies for promoting the event to attract an audience. Every time I heard about a new detail, the amount of time I dedicated to practicing my singing increased as well.

"If the audience is bathed in Ado's voice at a live show, they'll be overwhelmed. Everyone will be floored by that voice." Hearing Chigira-san's dignified voice over the phone, I didn't know how to express my gratitude; I could only repeatedly bow to him on the other end of the line, though he couldn't see me.

However—.

The happy times did not last long.

In mid-February 2020, Chigira-san called me. His voice was lower than I had ever heard it before.

"About the solo live next January... actually, it might become difficult to hold."

"...I knew it. It's impossible for someone like me, right? No matter how you look at it, it would be a financial loss."

"No, that's not it. This has nothing to do with Ado. Because of something called the 'novel coronavirus' arriving in Japan, not just Ado, but other artists might become unable to hold live performances altogether."

"U-um... you mean because of an unknown virus?"

"Yeah. Depending on the situation, live shows may be impossible across all of Japan for a while."

I felt as if the sky I had been looking up at had shattered and fallen upon me. Shaken, I managed to answer only "I understand," and hung up the phone with trembling hands.

From the first time I met Chigira-san, there had always been the "problem of potentially not being able to do a live show." Whether it was failing to fill the capacity because no one came, or me panicking and running away halfway through. But by talking to Chigira-san every day, singing, and planning the production, I fought against my weak, insecure self every single day.

"I will make this solo live a success, no matter what. Unless a meteorite hits us, I'll find a way to make it happen."

I had once said something like that to Chigira-san.

And then, as if by some cruel joke, an unknown virus—equivalent to a meteorite—actually appeared. It wasn't just in Japan; apparently, it was spreading worldwide and beginning to affect daily life. This wasn't about failing to fill the venue or running a deficit; the enemy was a virus. There was no way to win against that.

"What do I do now? What happens to me?"

Overwhelmed by shock and frustration, I couldn't stop talking to myself.

It wasn't even at the level of sadness or regret. Before desires like wanting to sing or dance, the very idea...

...that I couldn't meet or talk to people was simply incomprehensible.

I desperately tried to pull my mind back from the brink of panic. It wasn't just Japan. People all over the world were currently flustered by this same reality. Understanding this, I managed to swallow the scream that had risen to the back of my throat.

I turned on the television and watched the news. Even as a high school student, I could tell that this was an unprecedented crisis for humanity. The novel coronavirus, confirmed in Wuhan, China, in December 2019, landed in Japan in January 2020. By February, the number of infected people rose, and on March 1st, the WHO (World Health Organization) announced that "the novel coronavirus can be called a pandemic." Concerts, plays, and events were labeled "non-essential," and most of them were postponed or canceled.

A state of emergency was declared. Naturally, live venues, theaters, and event halls suspended operations one after another. Until March 2020, there had been lives for senior artists signed to Cloud Nine that I used to attend, but after the WHO's pandemic declaration, everything was canceled. On March 24, 2020, it was decided that the Tokyo Olympics and Paralympics scheduled for the summer of 2020 would be postponed by one year, and eventually, in April, Japan's first state of emergency was issued.

Of course, Chigira-san had not forgotten about my solo live.

"I don't know when this pandemic will subside or when lives can resume. Therefore, we have no choice but to put the Zepp show for January 2021 on hold for now."

"...Yes, I understand."

The world of hope Chigira-san had shown me vanished in an instant.

After hanging up the phone, I slumped down in the middle of my room.

Due to the effects of COVID, the Actors School went into complete closure starting in early March. With all this spare time, I studied for my correspondence high school and continued posting "Utattemita" videos, but I just wanted to escape reality. Most of my heart was occupied by video games.

During the pandemic, I didn't feel like playing competitive games, so I picked up *Animal Crossing: New Horizons*, which is the polar opposite of a bleak, combative world. Spending time with the healing villagers allowed me to forget—if only for a little while—the fear of the virus and the sadness of my vanished solo live.

I spent most of my days as a resident of *Animal Crossing*. Before I knew it, my sleep schedule shifted; I would wake up at noon and play games until I heard the call that "dinner is ready." My back grew more and more hunched, and my breathing became shallow. My heart felt blocked by

the fact that I didn't know what would happen in the future. As I whimpered and sniffled, my willpower completely drained away.

Chigira-san must have been frantic dealing with the cancellation of his artists' lives and switching events to online formats, yet he still called me almost every day despite all that.

"Are you doing okay physically? What are you doing every day?"

"Yes, I haven't stepped a foot outside, so I'm safe from infection. I play *Animal Crossing* every day. Hahaha."

Chigira-san never got angry at me for my lifeless laughter. He would simply say, "Well, talk to you tomorrow," and hang up. I would then return to spending my time with my Nintendo Switch in hand.

If it had been the old me, I probably would have stayed sunk in this swamp of self-indulgence and let several months slip by in a flash. However, while living those days, another version of myself began to click her tongue in annoyance.

Is this really okay? Are you planning to give up on your dream of standing on stage?

I have to do something!

Think! Use your own head!

My ideal debut was for Ado—the "mysterious Utaite"—to suddenly appear on the stage at Zepp DiverCity and make her solo live a massive success. An unknown singer, not even signed to a record label, filling Zepp to capacity and making industry insiders buzz with, "Who is this?" and "This singer is incredible!" It was a world far removed from someone as socially awkward as me—a truly legendary night.

But that roadmap had vanished like bubbles in the wind. I was told "you mustn't meet people," "you mustn't gather," and "lives are non-essential." My ideal crashed to the ground with a heavy thud.

I hate myself, and moreover, I am weak. That is exactly why I wanted to leave a mark on both myself and others that would clearly remain.

So, what now?

If I don't do it now, I'll surely grow into an adult while still carrying this complex. When I felt as though I had been pushed to the edge of a precipice—like a wave crashing white against a sheer rock wall—the version of me that used to cry because she couldn't achieve anything seemed like a completely different person.

In that case, there's only one option left: a major debut!!!

I want to make a living in the world of music, just like the Utaite I respect, Mafumafu-san and Soraru-san. To do that, I will become a professional, release an album, and become an Ado that everyone knows.

It seemed like a reckless goal. Even so, I didn't care; I wanted to take on the challenge.

Having made up my mind, I called Chigira-san.

"Throughout my time as a student, I haven't had a single memory that feels like 'youth.' If things stay like this, when I'm asked about my school days in the future, I won't have anything to answer. That's why I absolutely want to leave my mark while I'm still in my teens. I've given up on the solo live because of COVID. So, I've set a different dream and goal."

"What is it?"

"I want to make my major debut while I'm still a high school student."

"I can't do things the way everyone else does. Even though I'm a 'high school girl,' I don't really understand romance talk, and I don't know what's trending. I don't have friends to go to festivals with wearing yukatas, and I have no memories of sports days or cultural festivals. I was always alone. I haven't done a single thing that everyone else does. That's why... precisely because I can't do the same things as everyone else, I decided to take a step that is different from anyone else's. If I can make my major debut, I feel like I can live as someone who has broken out of her own shell."

Wait, what on earth am I talking about...? While I scolded myself internally, the momentum of the moment had already pushed the words out.

"Hmm."

On the other end of the smartphone, Chigira-san groaned. The way his voice trailed off made me brace myself, certain that he was about to follow up with, "That's impossible on such short notice." But the words that came back were different.

"Alright, let's do it. The first step is finding a record label."

In that instant, an indescribable surge of exhilaration welled up from deep inside me. I gripped my phone tightly and gave a short, simple answer: "Yes."

I began to feel that the fact that the pandemic had prevented my solo live show at Zepp was actually destiny.

If the solo concert had happened as originally planned, what kind of path would have awaited me? If it had been a success, I might have made my major debut, but it could have just as easily taken another year or two. And if it had failed, my spirit might have withered with a quiet *shrrr* sound, leaving me unable to ever stand up again.

My daily conversations with Chigira-san began to take on a new intensity. I could tell from his words that he was truly serious about this.

"Which record label you sign with will affect your entire career as an artist. We have to find a company that's okay with you not showing your face, allows the distribution of instrumentals*, and lets you do 'Utatemita' videos however you like. We need a label that accepts those kinds of conditions. Also, there will likely be singing tests, so please prepare for that."

*Instrumental: Short for instrumental music. Tracks consisting only of the accompaniment without vocals, such as off-vocal or karaoke sources.

Looking over the list of songs Chigira-san sent me, I did nothing but sing at home. Singing not only Vocaloid songs but also tracks by foreign artists I had never heard of felt like a game where I was clearing stages of increasing difficulty; it gradually toughened me up.

One night, before hanging up the phone with Chigira-san, words that had been lingering in my mind accidentally slipped out.

"By the way, there's something I've wanted to ask for a while..."

I paused for a moment before continuing.

"Why are you helping someone like me? When you first met me, what did you think of me?"

From the moment we met, I had spoken of nothing but reckless dreams. I had always wondered why Chigira-san was so serious about trying to make them come true when most people would have just ignored me.

Chigira-san remained silent for a few seconds before he began to speak.

"When we first met, your eyes were locked onto mine, but you looked away immediately. It was funny because I could tell you were on high alert, debating whether to run away or stay put. I think that might have been the first time in my life I've seen someone actually recoil like that. Then, I felt that you really cherished your long hair and your clothes. Your jacket, blouse, skirt, and shoes weren't flashy by any means, but you had a great sense of color and design. I wondered if you loved fashion and clothing. As for your personality... well, I got the feeling you were on the gloomy side. But I also thought that while you lacked confidence in yourself, you were an honest girl with strong convictions. I believed you were someone who would never run

away when fighting for the people or things you love. I thought that if we did something together, it would definitely succeed—and that it would be fun."

...I had never been told anything like that by anyone in my life.

"Hmph, so that's what you were thinking..."

I replied bluntly without thinking. However, the backs of my eyelids grew hot, and I realized tears were welling up to the edges of my eyes. Saying something like that so suddenly was foul play. *Fun?* Since when do I look *fun*? And "someone who would never run away" or "someone who can fight"—I've never once been told those things.

In Chigira-san's words, there was a straightforward expectation and trust that wasn't a joke or a mere social pleasantry. A mixture of embarrassment and happiness made my face flush hot.

"I wonder if your intuition is actually ever right," I replied lightly.

Even as I said it, I was making a quiet resolve in my heart.

I would find a record label, have them listen to my singing, and I would absolutely seize a major debut while I was still in high school. Just so Chigira-san could tell me, "My intuition was correct."

Chapter Two - The Rise of the "Usseewa" Phenomenon

March 2020. I made a decision of my own volition: I was going to quit the Actors School. Having begun searching for an agency or record label that would sign me with the goal of making my major debut, I had steeled myself to plunge into the professional world as the Utaite known as Ado.

I had decided to attend the Actors School for all three years of high school because I wanted to become a better singer and dreamed of one day turning professional. However, the teachers at that school had virtually no expectations of me.

Normally, I am timid and clumsy, but in that moment, a switch flipped somewhere inside my heart. I told myself, "The only way to prove whether I can make it or not is through results."

And so, I told my mother:

"I'm quitting the school, so you don't have to transfer the tuition for the third year."

My mother peered into my face with a worried expression.

"I've already prepared the money. You don't have to worry about that."

"No, it's not about the money. I just realized that school is no longer where I belong."

I felt nothing but gratitude toward my mother, who had taken on more work to afford my tuition.

Still, I couldn't tell her that I was suddenly aiming for a major debut. I felt that she would think it was too far-fetched a dream and that it would only cause her more unnecessary worry.

Around the time when people were staying indoors due to the effects of the new coronavirus, perhaps because everyone had more time to spend on their smartphones, the view counts for my "Utatemita" videos began to grow steadily. Partly because of this, I started receiving more messages from record labels in my Twitter DMs than before.

Now that I had left the school and was on my own, I figured I finally had no choice but to join a management agency. Naturally, the first person who came to mind was Mr. Chigira.

I had already told Mr. Chigira that I had quit the school. Even so, he never once said, "Join Cloud Nine; sign with us." Instead, he repeated, "You should choose and sign with whoever you are satisfied with. It's better to sign with an agency that you truly, from the bottom of your heart, want to belong to."

Despite this, my mind was made up. I would ask Mr. Chigira to let me join Cloud Nine. I would tell him that I wanted to aim for a major debut through Cloud Nine.

In late May 2020, when the state of emergency was finally lifted, I called Mr. Chigira.

While the phone was ringing, anxiety washed over me: *Maybe someone like me won't actually sell... maybe I'm actually being a huge nuisance... will he really let me join...?* But remembering how he had praised me on the day we first met, telling me my singing was "exceptionally good," I waited for him to pick up.

"Yes, what's up?"

Fighting the urge to just hang up the phone, I began to speak.

"Um... it's about the agency. There is no other agency that I truly, from the bottom of my heart, want to belong to besides Cloud Nine. Please, let me join Cloud Nine."

Mr. Chigira remained silent.

"...Is that a no?"

"Of course it's not a no."

"Then, please. I ask you to support me in my major debut and the dreams that lie beyond."

"I understand how you feel, Ado. Thank you. But first, consult with your parents. Once they hear the explanation from me and give their okay, we'll sign the contract."

"Yes...! Thank you so much!"

On June 9, 2020, at a coffee shop near my house, I introduced Mr. Chigira to my parents.

My mother and Mr. Chigira had spoken on the phone before, but they had never actually met. For my father, it was their very first meeting.

That day, as usual, Mr. Chigira was wearing short pants and flip-flops. Ordinary parents might have thought, "The president of the agency our daughter is joining wears flip-flops?" But my parents are a bit eccentric and didn't care about what was on Mr. Chigira's feet. Even I had wondered, "Is this guy okay?" when I first met him, so I felt my parents should have been more cautious... Just as I was thinking that, my mother began greeting him brightly in her usual manner.

"Nice to meet you, Mr. Chigira. Thank you for always taking care of our daughter. I look forward to working with you."

My father was excited from the start, flustering both me and my mother.

"Please take my daughter to the world stage! I've always thought she was a genius!"

You don't have to say things like that, I thought, though I managed to keep my mouth shut at the last second.

"The pleasure is mine. I am deeply moved to have encountered a talent such as Ao," Mr. Chigira replied straightforwardly. He then opened the contract he had prepared and carefully explained each point one by one.

"Is this part okay?"

"Yes, that's fine."

Because he explained everything so thoroughly, it took some time. But Mr. Chigira didn't skip a thing. When he finally finished explaining the last item, he said something unexpected to my parents.

"Just because Ao joins our agency doesn't mean she needs to change anything. She can pursue her dreams as Ado, and if she ever decides she wants to leave the agency, she can do so at any time."

He continued:

"Looking toward Ao's future, I will create a schedule that prioritizes her properly graduating from high school."

When high school students make a major debut, there are often discussions about taking a year off to push graduation to the following year, or even just dropping out entirely. But Mr. Chigira had told me before that it was better not to do that. Now that I was aiming to be a professional, I also felt that graduating properly in three years was important.

I vowed to my parents right then and there that I would properly face my studies—which had always been a secondary priority—and earn the necessary credits for graduation through reports, schooling sessions at the campus, and test results.

"Well then, I look forward to working with you."

After finishing the explanation, Mr. Chigira placed his hands on his knees and bowed to my parents and me.

"Please make my daughter a star!" my father exclaimed. "We don't know anything about this world, so we'll be relying on you for many things," my mother added. I also hurriedly bowed and said, "Ah, please take care of me..." but because of the nerves, my voice came out sounding incredibly gloomy.

My father and Mr. Chigira each pressed their seals onto the contract, and the agreement with Cloud Nine was successfully established.

And so, Ado, an artist belonging to Cloud Nine, was born.

When I returned home, I pictured Mr. Chigira's usual cool profile—the man who had exerted so much effort for my sake.

Takuya Chigira was the first adult I ever trusted from the bottom of my heart.

To be honest, I didn't want to rely on my parents. Precisely because they are blood relatives—a bond that cannot be severed—their presence felt like a heavy weight pressing down on me. Of course, I am endlessly grateful that they take care of my daily needs. But Chigira-san was the only adult in my life I could talk to about anything, someone I could share my worries with.

Chigira-san never once looked down on me—a nobody who did nothing more than sing inside a computer.

I truly have nothing but gratitude for him. Under this man's guidance, I thought: *I want to make it big. Is that even possible? But still, it would be great if I could.*

I stood by the window of my room. Feeling the crisp night air, I gazed silently at the city lights. I told myself that I would deliver my songs to the people living beneath those lights, and that the day I could shine would surely come.

Starting the next day, Chigira-san said, "Let's look for a record company that will sign you," and began presenting Ado to one label after another. He apparently handed over audio from my "Utatemita" videos and carefully explained the potential of Vocaloids and Utaite.

Furthermore, he presented certain "conditions" for Ado's activities. These were things I needed in order to continue being an Utaite: "continuing to post 'Utatemita' covers," "providing free instrumental tracks," "uploading music videos to Niconico Dōga," and "not doing any promotions that required showing my face." He even handled the negotiations for the signing bonus.

The conditions Chigira-san proposed were non-negotiable for me, as I desired a debut not as a traditional singer, but as an "Utaite."

For me, "Utatemita" is like a mothership. I would find songs on Niconico Dōga that made my heart race, cover them, upload them, and have people listen. Through that cycle, Ado was born and grew.

If I were to make a major debut and suddenly become unable to post "Utatemita" videos, Ado would cease to be Ado.

Then there was the "free distribution of instrumentals." Due to rights and management issues, this is typically a condition that is difficult for the music industry to accept. However, I have a dream that one day, someone else will do an "Utatemita" cover of an original Ado song. I don't want to go to a world where Ado's songs cannot be easily used for covers. I want to continue singing in this place forever. I want to protect the culture of Vocaloids and Utaite.

Chigira-san respected my feelings and prepared these conditions, negotiating them with various record companies. *Oh, thank you so much for doing this for someone like me.*

However, the world isn't that sweet. Every single record company that heard the conditions for Ado gave a flat "no." It was a total washout across the board.

I suppose it really is outside the norm for a complete newcomer to debut as an Utaite while promoting without showing her face...

After that, a contract remained elusive.

Amidst this, Company A had shown interest and sent me frequent DMs. Both Chigira-san and I grew hopeful that we might actually be able to reach an agreement.

However, through several exchanges, I discovered they had their own conditions for the contract. They required "a debut only after two years of training."

I thought: *Sure, it would be amazing to sign with Company A. But two years is impossible.* Because I wanted to achieve a major debut while I was still in high school. I couldn't even imagine who I would be in two years. I couldn't sing with all my might right now for the sake of someone seeking an Ado from two years in the future.

Seeing me frozen, as if the span of two years were an eternity, Chigira-san sent a message to Company A declining their offer.

Ah, it's back to square one. Is it just impossible to make a major debut while protecting my environment as an Utaite?! The headwinds were blowing so hard I was on the verge of giving up.

Just as my spirit was about to break, a DM arrived from Universal Music, one of the industry giants.

As usual, I shared a screenshot of it with Chigira-san via LINE.

"Nice to meet you. My name is Imada from Universal Music. I have been listening to Ado's songs. Would it be possible for us to meet once?"

Chigira-san called me immediately.

"I know Imada-san!"

As it turned out, Chigira-san and Imada-san were acquaintances.

"Wow, really?"

"I'll try to get in touch with him right now."

With that, Chigira-san hung up.

When I think of Universal Music, I think of the record company that my favorite artist, Billie Eilish, is signed to. The thought made my heart race and my palms grow hot.

About thirty minutes later, the phone rang again. Chigira-san's voice was bouncy with excitement.

"Let's go see Universal. He says he definitely wants to talk to you."

"Eh, I can go too?"

"He said he's waiting for you."

"But... if they hear those conditions, will it just fall through again...?"

"No, he said he's willing to accommodate them. He understands that Ado is singing in order to spread Vocaloid culture."

"You told him the conditions?"

"I did. He told me he'll make it work."

"...Are you serious?!!!!!!!"

"I think it means Universal evaluates Ado's singing that highly."

After hanging up once we decided on the date and time to visit Universal Music, I muttered to myself in a mix of anxiety and anticipation, "Is this actually real?" The place I was being invited to—as a mere slip of a girl—possessed the power to connect with listeners not just in Japan, but across the world. Not wanting to let this reality slip away, I hugged my knees tightly inside my dim closet.

A few days later. Even though the state of emergency had been lifted, everyone on the Yamanote Line was still wearing masks as I headed toward Harajuku. I met up at the station with Chigira-san—who looked incredibly suspicious in flip-flops, shorts, and a mask—and we headed toward a large glass building next to Togo Shrine.

So this is where the Universal Music building is. I've been to Harajuku so many times and walked around this area often, yet I never noticed it.

I was nervous. This was, of course, my first time visiting a record company. My arms and legs moved out of sync; I couldn't even walk straight.

Whoa, so this is a record company.

The entrance is so grand it's scary...

I wonder what floor the studio is on.

Oh, I want that poster...

While my heart was in turmoil, some part of my mind had already begun to solidify the desire: *I want to make my major debut with Universal.*

In the reception room where we were guided, Imada-san—who had contacted me via DM and was an acquaintance of Chigira-san—and his boss, Nagano-san, were waiting. The two stood up, and Nagano-san spoke with a pleasant expression.

"Nice to meet you. Thank you for coming today."

I awkwardly accepted the business cards they offered with both hands. After a brief self-introduction, we took our seats, and organized documents were placed in front of Chigira-san and me. Imada-san began to powerfully explain the debut plan for the Utaite Ado. I did my best just to follow the conversation while keeping my eyes on the papers.

Finally, Nagano-san's calm voice echoed through the room.

"I have listened to all of Ado's songs."

"Ah, thank you very much."

Nagano-san and Imada-san began talking to Chigira-san about how they wanted to hear more of my singing as soon as possible.

Ah, I wonder if those conditions will really be accepted.

As I sat there dazed with relief, I heard Nagano-san's voice again.

"If we are requesting songs, how about these people?"

I gasped. Listed in the documents were the names of some truly illustrious Vocaloid-Ps.

"I'd like to have Ado-san sing at our studio sometime soon."

A trial recording? Apparently, the songs to be recorded there would be decided through consultation between Universal and Chigira-san. But what on earth do you actually do when

singing in a studio? Could I really do it? I couldn't even begin to imagine it, since I had only ever sung inside my closet at home.

"Chigira-san, Ado-san, I'll be in touch with you both again shortly."

Imada-san turned back toward us with a smile. The pace of events was moving so fast that my brain couldn't keep up; the only words that finally managed to escape my mouth were brief.

"Um... yes, I look forward to it."

A few days later, Chigira-san sent me a list of song titles for the trial recording via LINE. It was filled with songs I had never sung before: "Kuchibashi ni Cherry" by EGO-WRAPPIN, "Kanzen Kankaku Dreamer" by ONE OK ROCK, "Tsutsumikomu Youni..." by MISIA, and so on. There were also several hit anime theme songs and some Western music.

Immediately after, Chigira-san called me.

"Do you think you can memorize the songs on the list quickly? You don't have to do the whole thing; just one chorus is fine."

"Is this... like an audition?"

"Well, it serves that purpose, but I think he mostly wants to hear Ado's actual voice rather than a video."

"That makes sense."

"Alright then, please memorize them."

"I wonder if I can do it... there are many songs I don't know... but I'll try."

The moment I hung up the phone, I shut myself in my closet. I listened to the songs on the list and sang them, then sang them and listened again. The unfamiliar songs were harder than I expected, and I felt a surge of panic from the very first note. I checked the lyrics while pondering their meaning, listened to the tracks, and sang over and over again through the parts that didn't go well. Occasionally, there would be a moment where it just clicked—a split second where my body felt suddenly light. Wanting to capture that sensation once more, I pressed the play button again.

And finally, the day arrived for me—someone with experience only in home recording*—to sing in a professional studio.

I was led into Universal Music's in-house studio and stood before a microphone placed in the center of the room. Nagano-san patiently taught me how to use the microphone and headphones, step by step. Chigira-san stood outside the studio, watching me through the glass.

"Alright, we're starting now."

When the voice of the recording engineer sitting next to Chigira-san came through my headphones, I felt as if I had been dropped into a scene from a movie.

To think that people were outside the recording booth, watching me while I sang. As I fidgeted in this unfamiliar environment, the melody of "Kuchibashi ni Cherry" began to flow into my ears.

*Home Recording (Takuroku): Short for home recording. The act of recording using equipment at one's own residence.

An exclamation cast away and steps amidst the dust
Spending time gazing at the dial, a number drawing an arc

The exit where things are spat out; bewildered—there's no point in crying all day
Walkin', the fruit is ripening

Drop it, cherry; looking up at the birds carrying them in their beaks
Cherry in their beaks

More important than competing speed is the landing
That red is beautiful

Cherry, always UP BEAT, deliver more to my heart; a moment's darkness ahead, send me more
red—cherry in their beaks

Let's scatter impurities and land toward a tomorrow where the halo shines

Once I actually started, the sensation was completely different from my usual home recordings. Because I kept singing while wondering, "Is this right?" or "Is this way of singing okay?", I felt an anxious sense that I might be messing up slightly.

I continued to sing the songs coming through the headphones one after another. I couldn't help but be conscious of the gazes from outside the recording booth. Once I had finished every song, I heard Nagano-san's voice.

"Alright, that's a wrap!! OK!!"

...It's OK? Just like that?

"Eh? Was it alright?"

"I think it was truly wonderful."

Chigira-san was smiling too.

"Let's discuss the terms of the contract, on the premise that we are signing you."

At those words from Nagano-san, my eyes widened in shock, and I hurriedly gave a deep bow. Inside, however, I was pumping my fist in victory, thinking, *I did it!*

When the live show at Zepp DiverCity had been ruined by the arrival of an unknown virus, I had been at a loss as to what would become of my life. After sinking into a deep slump for a while, I decided to leave the Actors School and vowed to leave a powerful mark on the world during my teens, declaring that I would make my major debut.

When I finally held the ticket that would turn that declaration into reality, a single fact was etched into my heart:

Dreams really do come true.

You have no choice but to decide your own life for yourself. Age has nothing to do with that decision.

I, a mere seventeen-year-old high school student, was able to sign a contract with Universal Music as an Utaite belonging to Cloud Nine. A great wave of life had swept me up and carried me to a place entirely different from where I had been.

The thought made my body tremble slightly. But it was different from the fear that had bound me since childhood.

It was a trembling heart, shaking every cell in my body.

I could feel it clearly; my heart surged with excitement at the reality unfolding before me.

At the end of June 2020, once the formal contract with Universal Music was finalized, my surroundings suddenly became hectic. It felt as if time were moving at double speed.

Chigira-san sent me a list of dozens of songs, accompanied by a short message:

"Please memorize these and make sure you can sing them."

Japanese songs, Western songs, tracks I had never heard before—no matter how difficult the melody, I listened to them all relentlessly, drilling them into my body and singing continuously inside my closet. For someone like me who had only ever sung Vocaloid songs, it was necessary to bathe my entire being in the melodies of various genres, as if they were sunlight.

There are songs in this world so difficult to master that they could break your spirit. But I didn't want to betray the expectations of Chigira-san or Universal Music, so I decided within myself that I would never say "I don't want to" or "I can't."

"I've consulted with Universal and have asked several Vocaloid-Ps to write the song for your debut."

When Chigira-san told me this over the phone one day, it felt like a distant memory from the time I had been shocked by him asking if I wanted to become a VTuber.

"I'm looking forward to it... and I can't believe it."

"What can't you believe?"

"That an original song is being made just for me. Even now, I sometimes take deep breaths or look up at the sky, wondering if I'm still dreaming."

"You only have a little while longer to be sentimental like that. From here on out, a thrill and exhilaration greater than any rollercoaster awaits you."

I love rollercoasters. The moment of screaming during that "floating feeling" of the drop is truly a liberation of the soul.

A smile escaped my lips at Chigira-san's words, telling me an even greater experience was waiting for me.

I can't wait!

"By the way," Chigira-san said, changing his tone and shifting the subject.

"Regarding the timing of your major debut—now that we've come this far, I don't think there's any need to wait. Let's aim for you to make your major debut within this year."

"Wait, there are only six months left this year!"

Chigira continued in a lighthearted tone.

"And you'll debut on the very last day of being seventeen. If the day after your debut is your eighteenth birthday, that would be pretty cool, wouldn't it? Ado, and your fans, will definitely never forget your debut date."

"Um, my birthday is October 24th, so the last day of being seventeen... that means October 23rd, 2020? Wow—there's almost no time left!"

The screaming rollercoaster had already started moving.

A major debut on the final day of being seventeen. That phrase fit perfectly with my ambition to leave a mark on the world while still in my teens. Immediately, the countdown began toward a debut on the eve of my birthday.

"Um, if possible... there are some Vocaloid-Ps I'd like to request for my debut song..."

While waiting for the tracks Universal was preparing, I gave Chigira-san the names of the people I personally wanted to ask for music production.

Chigira-san listened with a series of nods, and about a month later, he contacted me.

"The songs are all in."

July 28, 2020. In a meeting room at Universal Music, I listened to four demo tracks one after another.

The last one to play was a song by syudou, a Vocaloid-P who was among those I had requested.

The title was *Usseewa*.

When I first played it, what flowed out was a guide vocal sung by Hatsune Miku. From the very first phrase, something crawled up my spine, making me shiver; it took my breath away. The lyrics and the melody—every contour was sharp, piercing through me.

"I think this is the one after all."

Chigira-san and the people from Universal were of the same opinion. I, too, felt strongly drawn to this song.

Ultimately, *Usseewa* was chosen as the primary candidate for my debut song.

"The final decision will be made after recording. If Ado sings it and feels that 'it has to be Usseewa,' then it's decided."

I answered Chigira-san's words with a powerful "Yes!"

A few days later, we scheduled the recording for the candidate song. Right then and there, another reservation was made at Universal's spaceship-like studio, and Chigira-san and I left the building.

Until the way home, my head was filled with the exhilaration of having decided on a wonderful debut song. However, once I returned home and was alone, that heat gradually cooled, and in its place, anxiety began to seep up from the depths of my heart. The cause was the recording method.

Reflecting several times on the feeling of my first trial recording, I realized that I felt a strong sense of discomfort when recording while being watched by others. It wasn't just simple nervousness; it was a surge of shame and something akin to guilt welling up from somewhere. I felt as though people were watching me—peering into me—while I, someone who could do nothing, was "doing something."

Since the age of fourteen, I had always sung alone.

The time spent facing only my singing, unseen by anyone, was the only moment where I felt I was truly "alive." It was a place of refuge, where I was liberated from everything that bound me, if only while I was singing.

And yet, imagining myself singing over and over in a studio under the gaze of adults made me terrified, as if my entire inner self were being seen through. I feared that I would become unable to sing what I truly wanted to sing. I worried that by layering emotions according to someone's instructions, I would end up only capable of singing songs where I had suppressed my true self.

I felt as though I wouldn't even know if I could truly call such a song "my own."

To put these inner thoughts into words, I steeled myself and called Chigira-san.

"Um... if it's possible, I want an environment where I can sing alone. When I first went to Universal and sang in the studio, I realized that I'm not comfortable in that place. If home recording isn't possible, please let me record by myself. Otherwise, I don't have the confidence to keep singing many songs from here on."

"If you sing a few more times, won't you gradually get used to studio recording?"

My determination not to say "I hate it" or "I can't" to Chigira-san remained unchanged. But I couldn't back down here. In order for me to do my best, I needed a place and an environment

where I could concentrate on the song. That is why I summoned my courage and told Chigira-san for the first time:

"I cannot sing in that place."

Chigira-san simply said, "I'll think about it," and hung up. He might have thought that it was only natural to be nervous in an unfamiliar environment.

When I thought that I might end up recording my debut song in the studio while being watched by many people again, the part of my heart trying to compromise began to shatter with a series of sharp cracks.

Before I knew it, tears were dripping from the tip of my nose and chin. Lying on the bed in my room, I pressed my face into the pillow. Even when I heard my mother's voice calling me for dinner, I couldn't bring myself to leave the room. Feeling the presence of her softly opening the door behind me, I buried my face deeper into the pillow, not wanting her to see me.

My mother had no way of knowing about my obsession with the recording environment. However, because I wouldn't stop crying, she hurriedly called Chigira-san.

"Chigira-san, Ao is crying non-stop, saying it's impossible, impossible... did something happen?"

Triggered by that day, the conclusion Chigira-san reached was to let me try doing it alone for now.

"For now, let's try it alone. If that doesn't work, we'll change the environment then."

Of course, my answer was YES. I didn't even think about what would happen "if that didn't work."

"Yes, I'll do it. I'll try doing it alone."

Naturally, recording in my home closet was a no-go because of the possibility of noise interference, so Chigira-san rented a small music studio in Setagaya Ward, located in front of Shoin Jinja Shrine.

August 27, 2020—the day of the *Usseewa* recording. I arrived in front of the studio at the appointed time of 3:00 PM and sent Chigira-san a LINE message.

Ado: I've arrived.

Chigira: I'm running five minutes late...

Ado: Understood...

Five minutes later, Chigira-san arrived carrying a convenience store bag. He opened the studio door, bowed to the two staff members inside, and received an explanation about the studio's specifications. Since the equipment setup began immediately, I spent the waiting time looking around the studio thoroughly. Even though it was a small studio, to me, it felt as wide as a park I could run around in. It felt comfortable.

Once the setup was finished and the staff members gave me a small nod and left, Chigira-san placed three plastic bottles of water on a small table inside the studio and said, "Alright, do your best."

After thanking him, I emphasized the thing I cared about most.

"Please don't let anyone come in until I finish singing."

"I know."

Following Chigira-san's voice, there was a heavy thud as the door closed, and then I was alone. When I saw Chigira-san's figure across Route 246 through the studio window, words spontaneously welled up inside me.

"Chigira-san, thank you so much. I'll sing here. I'll get through this on my own!"

During the studio recording at Universal, I felt as if I were on a boat rocking violently in the wind. But now, my center of gravity had returned, and I stood firm like a great tree. Above all, breathing was easy, and my vision felt open.

Of course, there was tension in recording a debut song in an environment where I would receive no advice from anyone. Standing alone in the middle of the studio, I placed the laptop I brought from home on the side table and connected the microphone to the studio equipment. Once preparations were complete, the moment I glanced around, I remembered my usual closet. I felt the taut string within me loosen just a little bit.

Here, just like in my closet, I can sing while sitting alone.

I had caused a scene by crying, but I am so glad I didn't just swallow the feeling of something being wrong!

Just as I was about to start singing, savoring the joy, a LINE message arrived.

Chigira: I have to collect the equipment we used today, so let me know when you're finished with the REC!

Ado: Understood!

Chigira: Actually, it would be a huge help if you could tell me about an hour before you finish!

Ado: Understood...!

Chigira: Thanks.

Now, time to sing. I closed my eyes and took another deep breath.

The first song I sang was the top candidate for my debut single, "Usseewa." Since this song highlighted syudou-san's specialty—the expression of aggression and hatred—I had simulated singing it by surrendering myself to anger, following the lead of the provocative lyrics.

I have always been good at songs about anger; syudou-san's "Jama" and "Baka" were among the "Utatemita" videos that gained particularly high view counts for me. Therefore, I felt confident.

I'll show you exactly what righteousness and foolishness are

An honor student since I was little

Before I knew it, I had become an adult

A thought process like a knife

Not that I actually possess one

But I haven't played enough, something is missing

It's a problem, and it's someone's fault

Just drifting in confusion every day

Well, I guess that's how it is

Naturally keeping up with the latest trends

Checking economic shifts during the commute

Entering the workforce with a pure spirit

These are the natural rules for a working adult

Hah? Shut up, shut up, shut up!

I'm healthier than you think

Everything about you is so mediocre

You probably wouldn't understand

Ah, it suits you well

That melody that is neither good nor bad

Shut up, shut up, shut up!

Our brains are built differently, so there's no problem here

I took a sip of water to cool down my heated heart. Suddenly, the old folktale "The Crane's Return of a Favor" popped into my head, and I let out a small laugh. "Please, never look inside." So saying, the crane who had transformed into a human woman closed the sliding door to weave cloth.

In this studio where no one else is allowed, I am facing a song that I've staked my life on. To polish it into the greatest possible track, I am raging and screaming until my emotions are shattered into pieces. I am exactly like that crane, plucking her own feathers to weave the cloth.

I laughed, drank more water with enough force that my throat made a gulping sound, and sang again. Matching my voice to the explosion of my own emotions, I raced through the world of "Usseewa." After about an hour and a half had passed, I sent a LINE message to Chigira-san.

Ado: I think I'll be finished in another hour. But please don't come in until I'm done.

Chigira: Got it!

The recording ended as planned in two and a half hours. Once it was over and Chigira-san returned to the studio, the first thing that crossed my mind was, "If this audio isn't good enough, I'll have to go back to studio recording... I hate the thought of that." Consequently, my face was a sullen mask, far removed from any sense of accomplishment.

After returning home, I sent the audio recorded that day to Chigira-san via an uploader, and he called me shortly after.

"It was amazing! However, there's just one spot I want you to fix."

The request concerned the part "I'm healthier than you think," which I had sung in falsetto; he wanted me to sing it in my natural chest voice instead. Yes, certainly, that would add more power.

"Yes, I understand! I think I can do it."

I decided to re-record that specific part on a different day when I recorded the next song. A week later, at the studio in front of Shoin Shrine, I was scheduled to record "Readymade," written and composed by the Vocaloid-P Shri, using the same style as "Usseewa." While "Usseewa" had been almost decided as the debut song, Chigira-san mentioned that "Readymade" was too good to pass up, so we recorded this one as well.

In the end, after comparing the two songs, Chigira-san and Universal gave the OK to "Usseewa," with the one corrected section. It was decided that the audio I had recorded alone in the studio would be used exactly as it was.

"The debut song is definitely going to be 'Usseewa'."

When he told me this over the phone, I nodded quietly, saying "I see," while asking Chigira-san the thing I was most concerned about.

"Um... moving forward, can I continue to record alone, always in this style?"

"Yeah, that's fine. Now that I know you can do it, I'll make sure you can keep recording alone."

"Thank you so much!"

Yes! I felt a wave of relief. I was so happy. From now on, I could face my singing in a private space, at my own pace, until I was satisfied. Realizing this, I couldn't help but beam with joy.

"By the way," Chigira-san added, as if suddenly remembering something.

"Ado, you're always so thoroughly prepared for your recordings—good girl, good girl."

Eh. I had never been told something like that in my entire life. While blinking several times in surprise, my response was delayed.

"...No, I still have a long way to go. But, thank you."

And so, it was decided that I could continue renting the studio in front of Shoin Shrine for my recordings.

After recording, the next step was to decide on the visuals that would represent Ado.

The original plan was to produce these later, specifically for a live performance at Zepp DiverCity on January 10, 2021. However, due to the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic, my major debut happened nearly three months earlier than planned—on the final day of my seventeenth year—meaning the production of the artist photo had to be rushed.

"What should we do about the artist photo?"

"I'd prefer not to show my face; I want it to be an illustration."

"I understand, but the question is whether Universal will agree to it."

At that time, "Vocaloid" and "Utaite" had not yet fully permeated general society. If you were talking to someone about it, you first had to explain "what a Vocaloid is." This was no exception even within the music industry; often, the line between a "singer" and an "Utaite" was not fully understood.

Chigira-san acted as my interpreter, carefully explaining my wish to the people at Universal.

"For an Utaite, the illustration is their 'face.' The world of Vocaloid is created when the songs of a Vocaloid-P, the visual illustrations, and the vocals of an Utaite come together. Therefore, I want Ado to debut with an illustrated artist photo, without revealing her real name or face."

A few days later, I received official approval to operate using an illustrated visual.

Now, all I needed was the ultimate illustration!

But who should I ask, and what style should I go for? While I was racking my brain inside my closet, Chigira-san called me.

"Let's ask a rookie illustrator. And let's try to keep it as the same person for as long as possible. That way..."

"That way, the people watching will find it easier to remember, 'This is what Ado looks like.'"

"I see..."

"In celebrity terms, it's better to have someone like an exclusive makeup artist or a stylist. Someone who can draw Ado as she is in that moment, and someone who can protect Ado's image. If it's a rookie illustrator—then they can grow and evolve together with Ado."

"That sounds great... that's perfect."

Actually, there was someone I wanted to ask for the illustrations.

"In that case, I want to ask ORIHARA-san, who has been drawing fan art of me." ORIHARA-san had said they were a fan and had been creating fan art; their work possessed a mixture of eeriness and fragility. While it was dark and shadowed, it also held a sense of vitality, as if a mystical light were shining through. I had already been using their illustrations for my YouTube and Twitter icons with permission, but I would be happy if we could make it official after my major debut.

Chigira-san contacted ORIHARA-san immediately. Before long, word arrived that "ORIHARA-san has accepted," and the following day, Chigira-san forwarded a rough sketch to me. Attached was a single line of a message from ORIHARA-san:

I believe this is the image of Ado.

Ah, this is it! This is exactly it!!!!

A single illustration of "Ado" standing with a powerful gaze. ORIHARA-san had produced an illustration that hit the mark perfectly, matching my ideal. I wrote a message expressing my raw emotion and gratitude for having met such a person, to which Chigira-san replied:

The artist photo is decided then. I spoke with ORIHARA-san, and rather than just being an illustrator, I'm thinking of asking them to be involved moving forward as Ado's image director.

I agreed without hesitation. I became even more impatient for my debut and the days that would follow.

Finally, the day before my 18th birthday—the debut date of October 23, 2020—approached. From early October, Chigira-san came up with an effective announcement plan to gradually build anticipation day by day and shared it with me.

Chigira: Regarding the announcements, is it okay if I just give you a bulleted list of things that need to be said?

Ado: Yes, that's fine!

Chigira: 8th

- Announce that you have signed with Virgin Music, a label under Universal Music.
- Tell them to check YouTube and Twitter every day at 20:00 starting today for information.
- Do not mention the debut yet.

9th

- Release the artist photo.
- Mention it was drawn by ORIHARA-san.
- A word or two about the artist photo.

10th

- Announce that the major debut with Universal Music has been decided and that the first original song has already been produced.

11th

- Announce that the title of the debut song is "Usseewa" and describe what kind of song it is.
- Announce a limited quantity sale of original masks as debut commemorative merchandise, starting on the 15th at 20:00.
- Mention that the mask design was also done by ORIHARA-san.

12th

- Announce that the debut date has been set for the final day of being 17.
- Announce that the digital distribution of the debut song "Usseewa" begins on the 23rd at 0:00. Worldwide release.

13th

- Mention that the debut song "Usseewa" was written by syudou-san.

14th

- Release the jacket art.
- Mention it was drawn by WOOMA-san.

15th

- Start selling the masks.
- Thank everyone for following along with the string of news.
- Tell them to look forward to more information in two days.

And then, on the morning before "Usseewa" was released, I received this LINE message from Chigira-san:

Good morning. Congratulations on your last day as an indie artist. Let's make you a global Ado.

"Usseewa" would be distributed at 0:00 on October 23.

At 23:55 on October 10th, I was poised in my room, accidentally saying out loud, "Five minutes left!!" If this were when I was a child, there would have been an announcement saying "CD released today," but because it was a digital release,

there was no such thing.

I stared at the second hand of the clock in my room, clutching both hands tightly as if preparing to leap. Because the moment it hit 0:00, I wanted to jump and welcome my debut.

Five seconds left... 4, 3, 2, 1, Jump!

Yes, I was in mid-air. I did it; I debuted in mid-air!

On October 23, 2020, the Utaite Ado released the debut song "Usseewa" through Universal Music and achieved her long-awaited major debut. After frolicking over my "mid-air debut," I moved into the silence of my closet to listen to "Usseewa" alone. The voice coming through the headphones... ah, it was incredibly angry.

This song puts a spotlight on the expression of anger that I hold dear. While not every lyric applies to me personally, the triggers for that surge of anger and the rebellious spirit of wanting to leave a mark on the world synchronized perfectly with my feelings over the past few years.

You're just completely mediocre

Someone like you probably wouldn't understand

Ah, how boring

How many times are you going to make me hear that memory?

I had actually been exhausted by the teachers at my actor's school, who repeatedly told stories like, "You know, I met this artist, recognized their talent in an instant, and raised them." It was exactly like the world described in the lyrics.

When the music video premiered on YouTube at 20:00 on October 23, about 3,500 people watched it together. I was truly happy, and I bowed my head many times to the people on the other side of the computer screen, saying "Thank you very much." Even when my 18th birthday arrived on October 24, I was anxious about the reactions of those who heard "Usseewa," and I spent my time obsessively tracking the view count.

I also checked the LINE MUSIC rankings over and over. There's no way it would just rocket up from the start. Even so, the numbers creeping upward felt like a run-up before a giant leap. As my expectations grew—thinking, "Isn't this amazing? Is something huge happening?"—the real-time ranking had suddenly climbed to 13th place.

My voice, reach far, reach further!

And to calm my overheating heart, I played games or watched videos of other Utaite, telling myself: even if I make a major debut, I am still me.

I had thought that if the music video on YouTube reached 100,000 views, it would be a huge success. Instead, the numbers skyrocketed far beyond my imagination, surpassing one million views in less than a week after release.

What does one million even look like? I had never encountered a number of that magnitude; I was beyond happy—I was bewildered. Then, on the night of January 13th, it hit five million views, and the momentum showed no signs of stopping.

If it hits ten million, that would be incredible... but surely that's impossible, I thought.

Yet, ten days later, it actually reached ten million views.

Whoa!! If you do the simple math, does ten million mean that one out of every twelve people in Japan is listening to this song? Wait a second—this has turned into something truly massive!?!?!?

"Joy" and "fear" surged within me simultaneously. This chemical reaction of emotions, which usually never mix, sent my heart rate skyrocketing.

As I sat there dizzy from the endless climb of the view count, I received a phone call from Mr. Chigira.

"Ado, you did it. This song isn't just a hit; this is going to become something unfathomably huge."

Something even bigger than this...? Mr. Chigira, are you a prophet...?

I played the straight man in my head, but I couldn't quite visualize what an "unfathomably huge hit" would actually look like in practice.

However, it didn't take long to realize that Mr. Chigira's prophecy was coming true.

One after another, "Utatemita" cover videos of *Usseewa* began appearing on the internet. In addition to ordinary people, many

creators—and even legendary Utaite like Mafumafu and Soraru—covered the song. Eventually, the trend spread to VTubers and celebrities, and the buzz grew at an accelerating pace.

Gradually, television programs began featuring "Vocaloid" and "Utaite," even putting together special segments titled "Currently Popular Utaite." However, I often frowned at these shows, thinking they were being rude.

That was because the Utaite being featured were people who had already been popular for a long time.

Still, I could clearly feel that the terms "Utaite" and "Vocaloid" were finally starting to reach the average living room.

By the end of 2020, *Usseewa* was climbing rapidly up the karaoke rankings. Soon, its lyrics and melody weren't just in karaoke rooms; I started hearing them throughout the city.

Kindergarten-aged children holding hands while walking would sing it.

Salarymen waiting for taxis in front of the station would hum it to themselves while fiddling with their smartphones.

People who knew nothing about Vocaloid were singing *Usseewa*. When I realized that one of my grand goals—to spread "Vocaloid" and "Utaite" culture to the general public—had been achieved, I felt a joy so intense it made my cheeks flush.

But for every good thing in the world, there is an opposite. On television wide shows, discussions were now being held under titles such as "Examining the Influence of the Hit Song *Usseewa* on Children."

"The lyrics 'Usseewa' are fundamentally inappropriate, aren't they?"

"Children don't think about the meaning of the lyrics. Look, we all went through a phase like that ourselves."

"Still, it has a negative influence on children. You're making them utter such aggressive lyrics."

"But the children aren't singing it with actual malice."

"No, no—isn't it actually scarier when someone utters aggressive words without even realizing it?"

Watching these opinions clash on screen, I didn't feel particularly angry. While I hadn't necessarily hoped for a debate of this scale, some part of me had expected that if the song became a hit, it would eventually be discussed on TV with both pros and cons.

To cause a controversy is to leave an impact on the era. Of course, the content of the discussion had negative aspects, but I reminded myself that the emergence of negative opinions was proof that the song had reached people beyond just the fans. I felt a sense of profound emotion that it had become so widely recognized by society.

In other words, this was the moment my desire to "leave a mark" was fulfilled.

Almost instantly, I became known as "the *Usseewa* girl" or "Ado from *Usseewa*." I had no complaints about that, because it was simply the truth.

For someone as naturally gloomy as me, my reaction was unusually positive. If I kept working hard, I believed that one day people would know me simply as "Ado," without needing those modifiers. I decided to work toward that goal. Leaning on the existence of the people who had supported me when I was a nobody, I felt from the bottom of my heart that I could keep moving forward.

Not only the song, but the fact that I didn't show my face also became a topic of conversation. During remote media interviews, questions often extended to my physical appearance. Since I participated with my video turned off, I was invariably asked, "Do you look like the illustration in your artist photo?" While I would ponder for a moment—"I... suppose so..."—the next question would fly in.

"Do you usually say 'Usseewa' like that in real life?"

"No, I've never actually said it myself."

"I thought Ado-san would be someone who was much angrier."

"I'm not angry every single day."

"What kind of situation would make you say 'Usseewa'?"

"No matter what happens, I don't think I'd say it in my private life."

These exchanges continued like some sort of comedy sketch. But I realized that people listening to the song naturally project the image of the music onto the artist. It was only natural for them to assume Ado = Angry.

On the 148th day after the release of the *Usseewa* MV, the view count finally surpassed 100 million. Around that time, the storm of bashing also intensified. I didn't feel the wind pressure directly, but Mr. Chigira—a one-man company president with no employees—bore the brunt of all the inquiries and complaints.

If I were the type of person who normally barked "Shut up!" at people and went around breaking things, I might have fought back strongly, saying things like "Huh? Don't screw with me" or "You're wrong." But in reality, I am far from that type of person; the more complaints arrived, the more I simply bowed my head in my mind, thinking *I'm sorry* and *my apologies*. When I thought of Mr. Chigira facing the backlash created by *Usseewa* all alone, my heart filled with guilt.

And beyond the *Usseewa* bashing, a different kind of shock awaited me.

Sometime after entering 2021, I found an amount deposited into the bank account I had opened when signing with Cloud Nine—a sum with a string of zeros I had never seen before.

Mr. Chigira had told me, "The royalties for *Usseewa* will be coming in soon," but I couldn't imagine just how much money that would actually be. When my mother, who managed the passbook, finished updating it and saw the numbers, she went past surprise and simply blinked repeatedly for a while.

"What do you want to do with this? This is Ao-chan's money, so I won't touch it. You manage it and use it however you like."

My mother spoke in a hushed voice at the breakfast table. I responded only by saying "I'm hungry!" and stuffed my face with the toast in front of me.

"Since we had to spend money on your school, I couldn't even give you an allowance... so if there's anything you want..."

"No, I don't need anything. Just leave it as it is."

My mother said nothing more and handed the passbook to me.

"You keep this, Ao-chan. Keep it in the drawer of your desk in your room."

I returned to my room and gently pushed the passbook into the desk drawer—a drawer I had almost never used.

The mere existence of that money felt a little frightening.

As I turned eighteen, my world began to change violently, with my major debut serving as the turning point. Many people knew the name Ado and the song *Usseewa* I sang; they sent cheers or criticisms toward me, despite knowing me only through an illustrated visual.

Even though I felt that nothing about myself had changed, everything in my surrounding environment was shifting.

The daily routine of playing games with friends, going to karaoke, and eating convenience store sweets drifted further and further away. In its place, I spent my time memorizing new songs, repeating recording sessions, feeling giddy over download and view counts, and stepping forward in search of landscapes I had yet to see. I believed that I could face the overwhelming pressure and the dizzying changes without running away. I truly believed it, yet I couldn't completely wipe away the fear.

I took a deep breath. To ensure that these unfamiliar emotions—colors born from mixing many different paints—didn't spill over, I gently steadied my breathing.

To produce hit after hit. To do that, I just had to believe in tomorrow and move forward. However, the pressure appearing before me...

As I faced the pressure and my own doubts, I had an "Achilles' heel" that no one else could possibly know about. It was the existence of my father.

After "Usseewa" became a hit, every time my father looked at me, he began spouting ridiculous claims, such as, "The reason you became famous is because I gave you an elite education from a young age by letting you listen to Queen and KISS," or "I am the one who created Ado."

He didn't stop with relatives and friends; he bragged to the master of his favorite bar and to his colleagues at work, proclaiming, "Ado is my daughter." Not only that, before I knew it, he had created a Twitter account and started declaring himself as Ado's father. *Ah, I have to tell him properly.* Realizing this, I stood before him without shouting or letting anger show on my face.

"I absolutely want you to stop revealing that you are Ado's father. You are causing trouble for Mr. Chigira as well."

"But it's the truth, isn't it?"

"It isn't. You may be Ao's father, but you aren't Ado's parent. I am. I am the one who gave birth to and raised Ado. Ado is not your possession. So please, stop involving yourself with Ado."

The man didn't even respond to my determined words. In that moment, my resolve hardened.

I'm leaving home.

Having decided to live on my own, I told my mother. She gave me her blessing, saying, "Ao-chan is already working, so you should do whatever makes you happy."

When I called Mr. Chigira to consult about moving, he told me, "Let me know your preferences for the location and the room."

"Well, it doesn't have to be that spacious. But I'd like a room with a large window where I can look down at the city view. Also, somewhere with a fairly large closet that can fit both my clothes and me."

A few days later, Mr. Chigira presented several candidate properties, and from among them, I chose a compact studio apartment that seemed to have a spacious closet.

In March 2021, having successfully graduated from my correspondence high school in three years, I signed the lease for the apartment in my own name on April 1st and gradually moved my belongings in. Twenty days later, my first experience living alone began.

On the night of my first day living alone, my father and mother visited my new room. Even when I told him, "I graduated from high school," my father simply brushed it off. He seemed far more interested in Ado—the persona featured in the media—than in his own daughter.

"My colleagues at work were shocked when I told them I'm Ado's father."

"I told you not to say things like that. I, the agency, and the record company are all troubled by it. If you do that, Ado won't be able to remain Ado."

In an instant, my father's face turned red, and outrageous verbal abuse poured from his mouth. It was a textbook case of "gyaku-gire"—getting angry at the person who is rightfully complaining. Not long ago, Mr. Chigira had explained over the phone several times that "Ado will not disclose any part of her private life; we ask for your understanding and cooperation," but he refused to listen. Recently, weekly magazine reporters who had caught wind of the rumors from somewhere had even been visiting Mr. Chigira, leaving him overwhelmed with dealing with them.

I had reached my limit.

As my father walked away from my new home, I whispered a small "goodbye" in the back of my throat. As the sound of the door closing echoed, I felt the door to my heart quietly close as well.

A person who threatens my dream and the precious work of many people with foolish self-display.

I cannot forgive that, even if it is a parent. The moment I decided this, the heaviness in my chest strangely vanished, and for the first time in a long while, I fell into a peaceful sleep.

Six months had passed since my debut.

As I released "Lady Made" and "Gira Gira" following "Usseewa," the impression of Ado—who people thought was always angry—gradually began to change. And I felt that this image was decisively rewritten with the release of "Odo" on April 27, 2021. It was a song with lyrics featuring wordplay set to a rapidly shifting musical style, and it significantly expanded my range of expression.

After the release of "Odo," Mr. Chigira, having finished discussing the schedule, began to tell me this:

"The moment 'Odo' came out, the professionals turned their heads toward us. People in the music industry and critics—the so-called music pros—are honestly saying, 'That girl is wonderful.' Of course, there might have been some contrarianism because of how she was criticized during 'Usseewa,' but now they're saying things like 'That song is a masterpiece,' 'Ado's singing and expressive power are tremendous,' and 'She won't end up as a one-hit wonder.'"

He continued in a gentle voice.

"Everyone has finally noticed Ado's singing. You've really worked hard to get this far. The result of the consecutive releases has taken a concrete shape, and it looks like you've broken out of

the one-hit wonder category. Congratulations. Great job. And thank you. Let's keep this momentum going and continue releasing one song every two months."

In 2021, the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic were still continuing, but my recording schedule was becoming increasingly dense.

"Yoru no Pierrot," released on June 14th, became a tie-up song for a drama, and with this track, I experienced what is known as a "Shibuya Jack" for the first time. A Shibuya Jack is a promotion where a single music video is played simultaneously across all the large digital screens around the Shibuya Scramble Crossing.

Come to think of it, right after the release of "Usseewa," I heard that the MV was playing on the monitors at Shibuya Modi for a week, and I went to see it with a friend. Looking up at the monitor, we told each other, "Oh, it's playing," while filming it, capturing a fragment of a dream on our smartphones. However, at that time, it didn't feel real at all; it felt like something happening to someone else. "I'll work hard so that more people—more of the people here—will get to know Ado."

I said that to my friend and looked up at the sky beyond the buildings of Shibuya.

Eight months since my debut. On the night "Yoru no Pierrot" was released, at the exact time the MV was being broadcast simultaneously on the large screens in Shibuya, I watched the scene from the backseat of a car driven by Mr. Kubota, the promotion manager for Universal Music.

People waiting for the traffic light at the crossing all looked up at the screens at once. Some were holding up their smartphones to record videos. Of course, no one noticed that the person herself was in the car driving past them.

"So that more people will know her." From the day I wished for that until today, perhaps that wish has been slowly coming true. Watching the profiles of the people illuminated white by the LED monitors, I quietly savored the joy.

Around this time, a woman named Ms. Endo joined Cloud Nine, where previously only Mr. Chigira had been. She was the first employee for Cloud Nine.

For about two years since establishing Cloud Nine in February 2019, Mr. Chigira had run the agency entirely on his own. That period had been a tumultuous time for him. Although he worked without sleep to earn the necessary expenses for the office, the impact of the pandemic that began in 2020 meant he could no longer obtain the income he had planned for. Consequently, Mr. Chigira had actually become an Uber Eats delivery driver.

I only found out about this some time after Mr. Chigira had stopped doing Uber Eats.

After finishing a meeting about a new song with Mr. Chigira, Mr. Nagano, and Mr. Imada at the Universal Music office, the conversation turned to, "Shall we order some Uber?" and Mr. Chigira began to speak amusingly.

"Until the agency got on its feet, I was helped quite a bit by Uber Eats. The pay is deposited weekly, and you can work whenever you like. Man, it really was a lifesaver."

"Eh," I murmured, momentarily speechless, as my mind raced. The studio recordings since joining Cloud Nine. The production costs for the many "Utatemita" videos uploaded before my major debut. It must have been a huge burden on Mr. Chigira.

"The studio fees until now... don't tell me those were also from Uber Eats deliveries?"

"Yeah, that's right. While Ado was singing, delivery requests would pop up one after another, which really helped."

Looking at the smiling Mr. Chigira, I remembered how I had been able to think only of myself back then.

"That's..."

"Well, it's nothing for Ado to worry about. Managing funds is the president's job."

I nodded slightly and bit my lip. Mr. Chigira continued, his eyes looking toward something in the distance.

"When I left the GReeeeN agency to start Cloud Nine, there were no artists signed, so I had to start by searching for artists. You know, I hardly ever went to live houses. Instead, I checked Instagram and YouTube, and when I found an artist I thought was 'the one,' I sent them a DM. The first people I reached out to were Misaki and Haruka Omiya, and in March 2019..."

"Two people joined us. Then in June, Miyuhan's affiliation was decided as well. But at that time, I had only just started the company, so there were various expenses. At that point, our balance sheet was in the red. To make matters worse, the lives and events we had been preparing for became impossible to hold in the spring of 2020 because of COVID. I had borrowed money, secured a venue, done rehearsals, and even produced videos—only for it all to go up in smoke without recovering a single yen... That situation continued until the autumn of 2020. In the midst of that, Ado's 'Usseewa,' released in October, became a massive hit. Ado and the other artists who trusted an unknown agency and joined us ended up saving the company. I can't thank them enough."

No, that's my line. I am more proud of my president than anyone in the world—a man who protected the things I hold dear alongside me, without ever showing a hint of how much he was struggling.

I kept those feelings tucked away in my heart, knowing they would sound cliché if put into words, and spoke while staring at my own fingertips.

"Is that black Uber Eats bag heavy?"

"Yeah, it's pretty heavy when you pack it full."

"You don't do that anymore, right?"

"Not for now. But I don't know what'll happen if things get tight again. I keep pushing myself to make sure the company doesn't go under. That's why I've decided to keep the Uber Eats bag in my room as a decoration—so I never forget where I started, hahaha."

I want to be strong like him. I want to become a person with a resilient heart, and the courage and drive to survive each day. If I can do that, I believe that one day, I'll be able to love myself.

When I think that, my chest feels tight and warm. And I felt that as long as I had this warmth, I could fly anywhere, far beyond the success of "Usseewa."

Like a bird spreading its wings, I felt myself catching an updraft.

Meeting Mr. Chigira, joining Cloud Nine, signing with Universal Music and making my major debut, the massive hit of "Usseewa"... It felt as if I weren't just climbing ten steps of a staircase, but leaping over a hundred at a time. Having gained this leaping power, I believed that even if I encountered public bashing or my father's dishonesty, I could keep flying forward on this momentum. Or rather, I tried to believe that.

However, around the time I grew weary of the midsummer heat, a crack suddenly formed in the fragile parts of my heart, and before I knew it, shards were scattered at my feet. There wasn't one clear trigger. Without knowing the reason, the suffering only increased; I became lost and felt as though I were being crushed by my own weakness.

As "Usseewa" resonated throughout the world, I suddenly found myself standing right in the center of a light more blinding than I could have ever imagined.

I was praised, attacked, loved, and hated—exposed to every possible emotion. Even though I was standing on the stage I had dreamed of, the intensity of that light slowly chipped away at my heart. Wavering between who I wanted to be and the voice of what society demanded of me, I lost sight of myself without even noticing.

I thought I could sprint through the storm at full speed, but the face reflected in the mirror held neither dreams nor hope. There was no light in my eyes; they were pitch black.

During those days, on a precious blog meant for connecting with my fans, I spat out words that could never be taken back. Things like not wanting to go to work, wanting to leave the venue early, or even wishing I could just die—nothing but things that a professional should never make public.

When I was typing the characters into my smartphone, it felt truly casual. I thought it would be enough if "someone" on the other side of the screen could just catch these overflowing emotions... and so I wrote them out recklessly.

No, I was even more superficial than that. In that moment, I had no awareness of being a professional; I was still in the mindset of an amateur—in the worst sense—from back when I used to upload videos to Nico Nico Dōga by myself.

Ah. I had finally dove into the world I desired, so why were these emotions overflowing? I wanted to vent them somehow, but since long ago, I have always felt a strong resistance to revealing my true feelings to others. The only person I can be honest with is Mr. Chigira. But I didn't want Mr. Chigira, who had supported me this far, to hear such pathetic words, and at that time, writing in the blog seemed like the only way I had to digest my anxiety.

Immediately after I posted it, I received a call from Mr. Chigira, who had read the text. And he scolded me without mercy. Looking back, he had never once scolded me since we met. He is truly angry.

Thinking this, I desperately followed his voice through the phone.

"I know things have suddenly become incredibly busy and that it's really tough. Until now, you only had to focus on singing, but..."

"...but now there are tie-ups, as well as interviews for TV and magazines. I am fully aware of how much of a burden this is placing on Ado, and I've supported you as much as possible. But do you not realize how much you worry the people around you when you write things like that?"

My thoughts failed to become words, and my fingers tightened their grip on the phone. As I remained silent, Mr. Chigira continued.

"I certainly think we are pushing you too hard for an eighteen-year-old, Ao. It's not just work; your situation with your father is difficult too. But listen—the one thing I absolutely cannot forgive is the phrase 'I want to die.' Never, ever let those words leave your mouth. When you are truly troubled or exhausted, don't write it on the internet; tell me first. Don't make the fans who find hope in Ado, or the people who want to work with you, worry!"

Between Mr. Chigira's strong tone and the truth of his words—which I had no choice but to agree with—I couldn't hold it back and burst into tears. Even though I tried to stop, I couldn't. I was like a kindergarten child.

"I always end up like this... I'm nothing more than a nuisance who just causes trouble for everyone—waaaaaaah!"

To me, screaming and crying over the phone, Mr. Chigira did not say more than was necessary.

"I'll delete that blog post on my end. So after this, get some sleep."

Even after the call ended, I continued to cry.

And then, I thought: whether I am eighteen or a fresh debutante, I am a professional. As someone who has been granted fame and honor, I did something unbecoming. My heart, which remained unchanged from my student days, had diverged from my growing name, and...

I had done something unbecoming. My heart, which remained unchanged from my student days, had diverged from my growing name, and...

I was so scared, so terrified, that I foolishly pitied only myself. I prioritized the pain in my own heart over Mr. Chigira and everyone at Universal Music who had promoted me. What childish behavior.

Since long ago, I had continued to avoid revealing my feelings to my parents or friends. As if the bill for that had finally come due, I realized I could only vent my emotions in this manner, and I blamed myself further as I looked back into my past.

Mr. Chigira's voice still echoed in my head. Looking at my smartphone through tear-blurred eyes, I saw that today was August 11, 2021.

August 11. Exactly one year ago today was the day the serialization of my favorite manga, **Act-Age**, ended. Remembering even that sadness sent my mood further into the depths. My eyelids were swollen from crying so much that I couldn't open my eyes. I washed my face in the bathroom and blankly stared at my miserable reflection in the mirror.

"Both last year and this year, August 11th turned into a day of heavy crying. I wonder what I'll be doing on August 11th next year, in 2022..."

Please, let something terribly sad not happen for a third year in a row.

Wishing this, I placed my hand over my chest and tried to calm my emotions. But the more I thought that, the more my inner child began to assert itself, like a toddler throwing a tantrum.

The same words had been circling around in my head for a while now.

"I want to go back to those days."

Back to the version of myself before my heart and time were worn down—back when I carried nothing: no name like Ado, no reputation, and no expectations.

As I gazed at the face in the mirror, a lid on my memories suddenly flew open. Happy music sounding in the distance, and sweet scents. Birthday cakes and lots of toys. The feel of books my father bought for me. Works that shone brilliantly beyond a small screen.

A warm and bright world from before I started hating myself. I was certainly there once.

— To Be Continued —